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### Demonstrating Resilience in *The Wednesday Wars*

The 1960s was a period of great cultural change in America, with many new ideas being formed in the civil rights movement, counterculture movement, and anti-war movement. Gary D. Schmidt's historical fiction novel, *The Wednesday Wars*, follows Holling Hoodhood's life as a junior high school student navigating life in the 1960s. The book explores themes of growing up, friendship, family, and identity. Resilience is shown throughout as the characters learn these lessons. In the novel, *The Wednesday Wars*, by Gary D. Schmidt, Mrs. Baker, Mai Thi, and Holling all demonstrate resilience as they overcome the challenges of the 1960s as well as the challenges of their personal lives.

One of the characters who shows resilience is Mrs. Baker. After the news of Mrs. Baker's husband, Lt. Tybalt Baker, reports that he is missing in Vietnam, the entire town was anxiously watching for him in the news. Holling comments on Mrs. Baker's reaction, remarking, "But you would never have been able to tell that she was holding her breath at Camillo Junior High. She moved through our classroom as coolly as if Khesanh were just a proper noun in a sentence that needed to be diagrammed" (Schmidt 157). Even though Mrs. Baker is going through a lot in her personal life, she still maintains a calm and collected front with her students. This is because as a teacher, she puts her students' needs before her own. She understands that the children need a

stable, confident adult amidst the scary things happening in the world. As a result, Mrs. Baker is a great example of resilience in the novel.

Mai Thi also demonstrates resilience throughout the novel. Mai Thi is Holling's classmate who fled the Vietnam War in the summer before seventh grade. The school cook, Mrs. Bigio, is still affected by her husband's death in the Vietnam War and blames her feelings onto Mai Thi. The week before December break, all the students each get a special "Something" as their treat. From Holling's perspective, he describes, "Mai Thi took her Something. She looked down, and kept going. She probably didn't see that Mrs. Bigio was pulling her hair net down lower over her face, because she was almost crying. And probably Mrs. Bigio didn't see that Mai Thi was almost crying, too" (Schmidt 113). Mai Thi is a young girl who is adjusting to a completely new life. She faces challenges such as the language barrier, singled out by some teachers, in addition to the trauma she must have experienced during the war. Mai Thi has to deal with all of these problems on her own, silently moving forward. She never shows how overwhelmed she may be. This shows that Mai Thi is an incredibly resilient character.

Furthermore, Holling learns to be resilient as the story progresses. Near the end of the novel, his sister makes the rash decision to run away with her boyfriend to California in order to "find herself." On the journey, however, she realizes that it was a mistake and tries to return home. When his sister is in dire need of financial support on her way home, Holling is the only person in their family who helps her. Holling states, "I was there when the bus from Chicago pulled in at 10:50. The Port Authority was all noise and rushing. The accumulated combustion from the buses had thickened the air. The whoosh and squeak and hollering of the brakes and the distorted announcements over the P.A. system and the newsboys hawking and the pell-mell of more bodies than belong in any one building gave the place a general roar. As for the floor, you

couldn't have found a greater confusion if the ceiling had been lifted off and the sky had rained down ticket stubs and newspapers and Baby Ruth wrappers" (Schmidt 232). Driven by his deep care for his sister, Holling navigates his way to New York City to visit his sister. The fact that he is only a junior high school student doesn't stop him. He lacked money and transportation, but was determined to find every possible solution to make it work. Holling demonstrates great resilience in the story.

In the novel *The Wednesday Wars*, Mrs. Baker, Mai Thi, and Holling all show resilience as they face various challenges in their lives during the 1960s. Mrs. Baker grapples with uncertainty for her deployed husband in the Vietnam War, while Mai Thi is constantly unwelcomed in America. The main character, Holling, shows resilience in his compassion for his sister. All the characters grow and change to become a better version of themselves as they resiliently conquer their problems, reflecting the culture of the 1960s.